

THE HISTORY OF ST JOSEPH'S RC SCHOOL

The plot of ground on which St Joseph's Primary School stands, was bought by the late Bishop John Murphy, then parish priest of Mater Dei. On the plot stood a stone built house consisting of a front room, two central rooms, an upstairs room, a kitchen and the usual outbuildings. The wall between the two central rooms was removed and this became the first Mass centre for the Catholics. Father Buckley was the first parish priest.

St Joseph's Primary School opened its doors on 21 January 1959. Sister Pius was brought out by car from Holy Rosary Convent to open the school. On that first day there were 14 pupils. Their names were: Patricia Connelly, Sharon Duthie, John Finch, Meryl Ireland, Wendy Lear, Beryl Machin, Jean McKinnon, Patricia Merrit, Cheryl Reid, John Sawyer, Elizabeth Smuts, Jennifer Stevens, Patricia Street and Andrew York.

The Mass centre was used as a classroom and it required a great deal of labour on the part of the men of the parish to move the heavy pews out after Holy Mass on Sunday and replace them with desks etc. ready for school on Monday and then to reverse the process on Saturday. Father Buckley who was residing in the house made the front room his bedroom/study and during school days left the premises before Sister Pius' arrival and returned when school was over. Sister Pius used this room as a restroom during the week while at the same time keeping her eye on the young charges.

Sister Pius was alone at the school for practically the whole of the first year. (Sister Pius passed away in 2005). Mrs Kennedy then joined the staff.

The school was growing and the upper room was brought into use and at a later stage, the kitchen.

The ground on the right side of the entrance was practically level and this became the playground. On this land the first "Sports Day" took place. The first fete for the church took place on the other side of the driveway.

On one Saturday afternoon the founder and parents of the school were invited to a tree planting ceremony and thus the trees on the boundary fence of the Cape Road commemorates these members.

Today, St Joseph's is 64 years old and has over 250 pupils.

There have been many changes to the school. The school now consists of a pre-primary and classes from grade 1 - grade 7. The principal of the school is Mrs Holly Allen. The motto of St Joseph's is VERITAS, which means - THE TRUTH.

The star on the school badge reminds us of the light which appeared above the head of St Dominic when he was born. It showed that he was to do great deeds. He founded the Dominican Order of nuns and these sisters founded our school.

Mrs Holly Allen, nee Hobson, took over from Mr Du Preez in February 2008 as the new Principal. Mrs Allen started her teaching career at St Joseph's RC School in 1979. She has 44 years of teaching at St Joseph's, with unbroken service. Mrs Allen holds the record of having the longest years of service at the school. Many changes have taken place during her reign.

A Gr 0 class has been added, a huge new Hall, with sound equipment and lighting, a Conference Centre with a kitchen and ablution block.

The old hall was converted into a library and computer room with 40 computers, a little kitchen area was added to the staffroom, and the bookroom was moved to another area. The old computer room was changed into a Phys Ed storeroom.

The old library was converted into a store room, 2 changing rooms for productions, a sickroom, and another office for the assistant secretary.

The old vibacrete perimeter wall was removed, and clear vu fencing was put up. Pallisade fencing was put up with two motorised gates on the sides of the school.

Safe parking was created for the staff, and a large area was paved on both sides of the school. The entrance for the children was moved to the side of the school closest to the Sacred Heart parish.

Motorised gates were fitted to the entrance of the school, these open and close at certain times, for safety purposes.

Mrs Allen's passion is at all times for the children of the school.

She is dreading the day that she is forced to retire, due to her age.